

Bramante

The initiator and leader of High Renaissance architecture was Donato Bramante (1444–1514), appointed chief architect in Rome when it replaced Florence as the artistic capital of Europe. After an intensive study of Roman ruins, Bramante created a new style of church, centrally planned, based on squares, circles and octagons, which expressed his ideals of geometry and harmony and incorporated elements of ancient pagan temples. Bramante's clarity of vision and fine sense of scale are expressed in the tiny, circular Tempietto at San Pietro in Rome (opposite), a Doric shrine built in 1502 on the traditional site of Saint Peter's martyrdom. The Tempietto is perceived as a High Renaissance masterpiece, fusing classical antiquity with new ideas. For instance, the slender Tuscan-style colonnade around the small cella (inner chamber) is topped by a semicircular dome on a tall drum, while the balustrade was new and inventive. Around the Doric entablature (the horizontal element over the columns), Bramante replaced pagan imagery with witty symbols of Christian liturgical instruments.

